

Asparagus and fennel risotto

This recipe has a slight bite and very **interesting** flavors and textures. Look for plump fresh fennel without blemishes. Cut from the softer white bulb rather than the woodier green stalks.

4 cups vegetable stock [1L]

1½ tablespoons organic butter or olive oil

1 small onion, finely chopped

½ cup finely chopped fresh fennel bulb, leaves reserved for garnish [60g]

½ pound tender fresh asparagus, tough ends removed, stalks cut into pieces 1 to 2 inches [2.5 to 5cm] long [250g]

1 fresh serrano or Thai pepper, seeds and ribs removed, minced

1 teaspoon unrefined cane sugar

1 cup Arborio or other risotto rice [200g]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

2 tablespoons freshly grated Parmesan cheese

1. **Bring** the vegetable stock to a simmer on the burner closest to your risotto pan. You will need a solid wooden spoon and a ½-cup [125-ml] ladle.
2. In a heavy-bottomed saucepan, **melt** the butter over medium-low heat. Add the onion and fennel and cook until the vegetables are softened, about 5 minutes. Add the asparagus and, stirring constantly, cook for about 1 minute, until it turns a brighter shade of green.
3. Add the serrano pepper and sugar and stir in the pan for 30 seconds or so. **Add** the rice and cook, stirring constantly, for 1 to 1½ minutes. Raise the heat to medium-high and ladle in 1 cup [250ml] simmering stock. The liquid should quickly boil and continue to simmer until you are finished.
4. Continue to **stir** without stopping, getting all sides and the bottom of the pan, so the rice does not stick or burn. Keep stirring until the liquid is absorbed and evaporated. Ladle in ½ cup [125ml] more hot liquid and repeat the process until the pan is again void of much stock.

5. After 15 minutes or so, **season** with salt and pepper and get a quick taste. Is your rice too crunchy? It probably will be, but this is the time for you to make choices. Risotto should be tender but firm to the bite. You may add slightly less liquid now at each addition until you get your desired results in about 20 to 25 minutes.
6. When the risotto is done, remove it from the heat, **stir** in the cheese, and season again generously with salt and pepper. Garnish with the reserved fennel leaves. Serve immediately.

SERVES 2 TO 4

